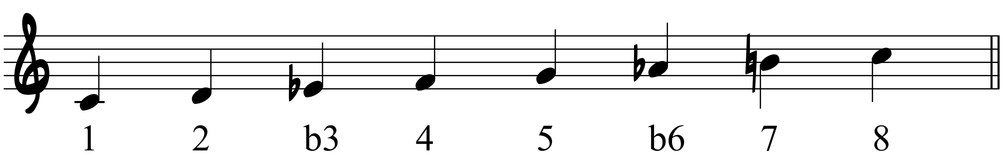
ii - V - i in Minor Keys

From Digging Deeper Video #49

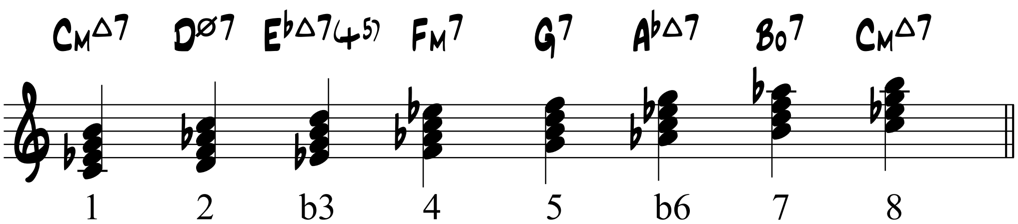
We see "minor ii - V - i's" in many songs played by jazz musicians, including in songs that are actually in major keys (there are plenty of major key songs that spend time in minor keys). For those reasons, we need to know how to clearly think about and play minor ii - V - i's.

1 In a minor key, we use the harmonic minor scale as our "baseline" tonalitly. We could use other scales, like dorian or pure minor, but traditionally we use harmonic minor because it's the minor scale that has a leading tone in it (ie. the 7th is a half step below the root). The leading tone is what gives us the sense that we are "in a given key." Without it, we are not "tonicized" as strongly.



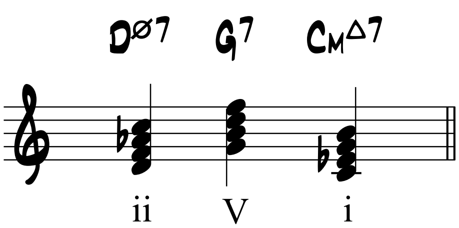
C harmonic minor scale

2 If we build diatonic 7th chords ("in the key of") off each note in the harmonic minor scale, we get these chords. We then analyze them to find out what chords we've written down.



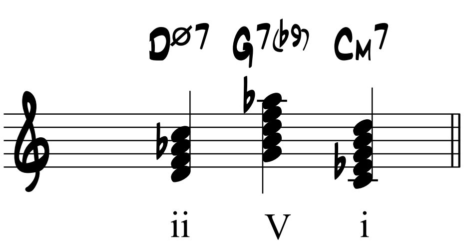
(every single note is from the C harmonic minor scale, remember)

3



So, this is why the "ii" chord is usually half diminished, the "V" chord usually dominant, and the "I" chord is of course minor. The "baseline" tonality (in this case, harmonic minor), defines the quality of all the other chords.

4



The "i" chord is technically a minor chord with a major 7th. This note gets used often in both classical music and be-bop. A pianist or guitar player might comp a minor 6/9 chord, or a minor 7 chord, but then solo with either the b7 or natural 7.

The "V" chord often has a 9th in it. In minor keys, it would be a b9 (an Ab), because of our original decision to use a harmonic minor sound. The b9 helps us hear the minor "i" a bit better.

DiggingDeeperJazz@gmail.com

Leadsheet

Kosma/Mercer

Autumn Leaves